

D'Ignazio & Klein (2020) "What Gets Counted Counts"

- Data feminism requires us to challenge the gender binary, along with other systems of counting and classification that perpetuate oppression.
- Nonbinary people are chronically unrepresented in gender data collected from user profiles
- Munir: If you exclude us from everything you don't have the right to say there aren't enough of us to warrant change.
- #Seager: "Women in poorer countries seem to be asked about 6 times a day what kind of birth control they use, but not if they have access to abortions or what sports they like to play."
- The process of converting qualitative experience into data can be empowering
- when thoughtfully collected, quantitative data can be empowering too.
 - So many issues of structural inequality are problems of scale, and they can seem anecdotal until they are viewed as a whole.
 - Ann Oakley: without quantitative research it is difficult to distinguish between personal experience and collective oppression.
- Although it is sometimes still considered in biologically essential terms, sex has a distinct cultural history
 - Traces back to ideas about democracy and natural rights emerging in Enlightenment Europe
 - ↳ Before this sex was broadly perceived hierarchically rather than binarily
- Before the 18th century western societies understood race as a concept tied to religious affiliation, geographic origin, or some combination of both (ethnicity?)
 - Race had very little to do with skin colour until the rise of the transatlantic slave trade in the 17th century, and even then it remained hazy until the scientific racism of the mid-18th century took hold.

- over the course of the 18th century increasingly racist classification systems emerged alongside pseudosciences like comparative anatomy and physiognomy.
- Provided a scientific basis for differential treatment of people of colour, women, disabled people, and gay people, by elite white men.
- Legacies of these defunct fields still visible
 - as machine learning techniques are increasingly extended into new domains of human life, scientific racism is returning.
 - machine learning attempts to identify criminals and criminality based on images of faces. (WTF)
- Data has to be classified somehow to be useable.
So how do we do that ethically?
 - Data = information which can be processed by a computer or using computer-like operations.
 - These categories can be conceptual (i.e. gender) or computational (Boolean, integer, string)
 - Classification systems are essential to any working infrastructure (computational, conceptual, physical)
 - Once these systems are in place they become naturalized and difficult to question or identify as influential.
 - Classification systems carry significant material consequences: Political representation, federal funding, etc.
 - Are the categories lacking or is it the system itself?
- Being counted means being made visible to the matrix of domination as a potential site for control.
- The absence of data, if represented, can be as meaningful as the data themselves.

Real / Fake names on Facebook

- System flags names with "too many words" or "unusual capitalization" which disproportionately affects Indigenous names.
- users can also report each other for fake names, which has been used in targeted harassment.
- It is so fundamentally important that individuals have the right to determine whether or not they are counted and how.

Colored Conventions Project

- most stories about abolition focus on white abolitionists, because theirs were the stories considered worth recording in print.
- The CCP's goal is to document and recognize the vital role of Black activists working within their own communities for liberation and an end to slavery.
- The CCP requires users of the corpus to commit to a set of principles intended to prevent the stories of these Black activists from being reduced to statistics or returning to unnamed obscurity. uphold
- They also ~~...~~ a memorandum of understanding acknowledging that although the official records of the Convention participants listed only men, they were only able to do this with the help of their community of women, whose stories also deserve recognition
- counting and classification are tools of power in themselves.
- "An intersectional feminist approach to counting insists that we examine and rethink the assumptions and beliefs behind our classification infrastructure, as well as consistently probe who is doing the counting and whose interests are served."
- when we count within our communities with consideration and care, we can work to rebalance unequal power distribution.